Faf and I – two old Affies – came together in a crisis, and batted, and batted, and batted.

Constantly encouraging each other to keep fighting, to keep concentrating, to leave anything wide, to get in line and defend, to keep going, we survived for five overs, then 10 overs, then 15, then 20 and eventually took our total to 77 for four at stumps on the fourth day. We had scored 32 runs in 29 overs.

We were fighting all right but, even so, the home side needed only six more wickets on the last day. Faf and I resumed our vigil under unhelpfully clear skies, with no prospect of assistance from the weather, and we kept going and kept going. We survived a few close calls and relied on some assistance from the third umpire review system a couple of times, but we kept going and safely reached lunch.

It was hard work, but I was relishing every minute. Ten years after Faf and I had been chased away from a school practice in Pretoria, we were batting to save a Test match in Australia. On a personal level, I wanted to prove to my teammates – and to myself – that I could be more than a stroke-playing dasher, that I was also capable of getting my head down, keeping my concentration and sticking around for the team.

My innings ended in the fourth over after the break, when I was bowled by a ball from Peter Siddle that cut back and took out my off stump. I had batted for just over four hours, faced 220 balls and scored 33 runs without scoring a single boundary and without even coming close to hitting a six. It was the second-slowest innings of more than 30 runs in the history of Test cricket, second only to an innings played by Chris Tavaré, of England, in Madras. More importantly, our partnership of 89 runs in 68 overs had kept alive our hopes of saving the match.

Jacques limped out to bat and scored 46 in just under two hours, but Faf kept going and going. Even though we lost a few wickets in the evening, even though we were never safe until the second-last ball of what was a long, tense and thrilling day, we finally reached stumps at 248 for